

City/County Monthly Update: June 23, 2026

11:00 a.m. – Board of Commissioners Conference Room

Commissioners Ron A. Smith, Colene M. Martin, and Gary L. Richardson; Nikole Guzman, Recorder

Chair Ron A. Smith. called the joint meeting to order at 11:00 a.m.

Additional Attendees: Aaron Cubic City Manager, Helene Lulich, Property Manager, Dave Streeter, Forestry Director (City Manager Aaron Kubik noted that the Mayor and City Council President were unable to attend due to prior commitments)

1. 6th and 7th Street Banner Approval Process

The group discussed concerns raised by a community organization regarding the process required to place banners across 6th and 7th Streets. Commissioner Martin explained that constituents had expressed frustration regarding the number of approvals required before banners could be displayed. City Manager Kubik provided historical background regarding the process and explained that banner permits fall under Oregon Department of Transportation (ODOT) jurisdiction rather than direct City or County control. Kubik stated that ODOT requires an application to include support from a local governmental entity and that the City previously acted as an intermediary for applicants seeking banner approvals.

Kubik further explained that the City discontinued its role in endorsing or sponsoring most banner applications due to concerns regarding freedom of speech issues, potential liability, and the significant staff time required to administer the process. He noted that the City now limits endorsements to events directly sponsored by the City, such as Boatnik, Art Along the Rogue, and Fourth of July celebrations. Commissioners discussed distinctions between support, sponsorship, and endorsement and acknowledged the need to review County practices and policies to ensure consistency with legal requirements while avoiding potential litigation concerns. Participants agreed additional review with legal counsel would be appropriate before considering any policy changes.

2. 250th 4th of July Celebration Collaboration

City Manager Kubik provided an update regarding the City's annual Fourth of July celebration, which will again be held at Reinhart Volunteer Park. Kubik reported that the event continues to grow each year and will feature food vendors, entertainment, fireworks, and family activities. He also noted that the City would be issuing a proclamation recognizing the nation's 250th anniversary and welcomed participation by County Commissioners during event activities if desired.

Commissioners discussed County participation in the celebration, including assistance provided through the Josephine County Transit system for event transportation services. Commissioner Martin noted the County's plans to decorate and illuminate the Courthouse in recognition of the anniversary celebration. Participants agreed that while a formal joint event would be difficult to organize at this stage, both organizations were contributing to community celebrations in their respective capacities.

3. General Discussion regarding City/County Properties

Discussion focused primarily on County-owned property located near Dollar Mountain and the existing trail system connecting to City recreational lands. Participants reviewed previous discussions regarding potential transfer, sale, exchange, or easement arrangements involving approximately 29.75 acres of County-owned forestland adjacent to City property. Property Manager Helene Lulich reviewed the history of the property, noting that the parcel had previously been offered through auction and had received bids exceeding the minimum asking price before being withdrawn at the City's request. Lulich also explained that the Assessor's Office had subsequently reassessed the property and increased its value based upon surrounding property transactions.

Commissioner Richardson observed that the property's highest and best long-term use may be recreational in nature given its proximity to existing City trail systems. Forestry Director Dave Streeter explained that the parcel provides limited forestry value due to access constraints and relatively low timber productivity, suggesting that acquisition of more productive timberland could potentially provide greater long-term benefit to County forestry operations. Participants discussed appraisal considerations, potential recreational uses, trail expansion opportunities, and the possibility of future collaboration between the City and County. No decisions were made; however, staff agreed to gather additional information regarding future recreational opportunities, appraisal costs, and potential policy direction for future discussion.

Additional discussion occurred regarding City and County property inventories, housing development opportunities, urban growth boundary considerations, and previously completed cooperative property transactions between the City and County. Participants agreed that continued coordination regarding publicly owned properties could benefit both organizations and the community.

4. Other/Additional Subjects Matters from Commissioners – ORS 192.640(1)

Commissioner Richardson raised House Bill 4084 and discussed potential planning opportunities related to wastewater infrastructure and industrial development within the North Valley area. Discussion focused on long-term sewer planning needs, potential grant funding opportunities, airport-area development, and the importance of infrastructure improvements to support future economic growth. City Manager Kubik indicated that the City would support efforts to obtain planning funding and recognized the importance of developing long-range infrastructure solutions for the North Valley Industrial Area and surrounding employment lands. Participants acknowledged that wastewater infrastructure remains one of the primary constraints affecting future development opportunities in the area.

The meeting adjourned at 11:55 p.m.